

Flex pane UXR

Contributor: Matt Murry, Senior UX Researcher



UX Researcher

Rachele Benjamin



UX Researcher 2

Elaine Zhang

We need to learn how well users feel about the size of the pane and all its behaviors

Prototype [link](#) password “Copilot”

Research goals

1. Assess how users respond to the new, more compact flex pane
2. Determine how well or poorly the pane’s behavior of remaining open at the tab level fits users’ workflows
3. Determine how effective or ineffective the interactions (dropdown from icon, docking) are at meeting users’ sizing and visibility needs, and identify customizations that may help us better meet those needs

Summary

Pane behavior | Many participants expected the window to shrink or dismiss when they interacted with the screen. With the caveat that we didn't get a lot of signal on 'why', users expected the pane to shrink when they engaged with the currently open window. Therefore, we recommend shrinking down the chat when users click on the page. The chat pane expands to a good length, but consider in future designs how it would look with wider output.

How the pane behaves on a tab level | Though there are moments when users may want the pane persistent across tabs, it's more of a nuisance to have to minimize the pane with irrelevant content vs. make an extra click to return to the previous tab. We recommend that Copilot operates at the tab level and carries conversation history across tabs. As a North Star, the pane should dynamically understand the tab content and then persist vs. not persist depending on how relevant the content is.

Docking in the sidebar | offers many of the same benefits as dragging and manually resizing; in particular, changing the size and getting it out of the way so they can view page content. Though participants acknowledged that docking the pane in the sidebar solves many problems, they felt dragging and resizing was the more intuitive interaction. We also recommend we replace the sidebar icon with something more recognizable (e.g., expand window) or add tooltips. As a North Star, users should be able to drag and resize the pane as well as dock it in the sidebar.

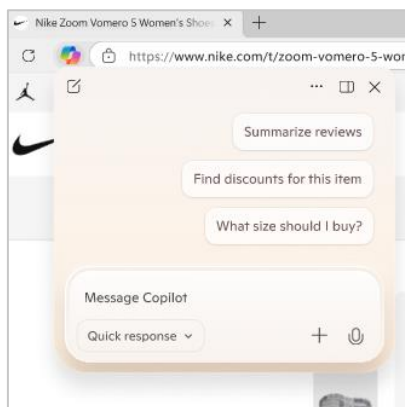
Method

Flex Pane

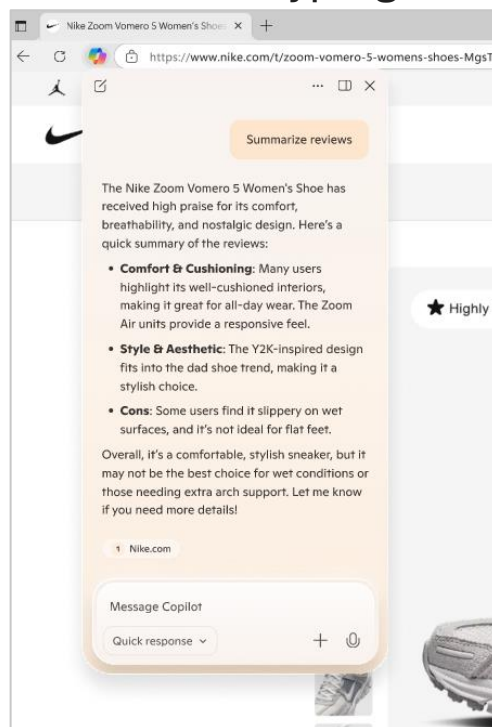
The prototype demos starting a chat, continuing the chat, and docking the pane in the sidebar

Prototype [link](#) password “Copilot”

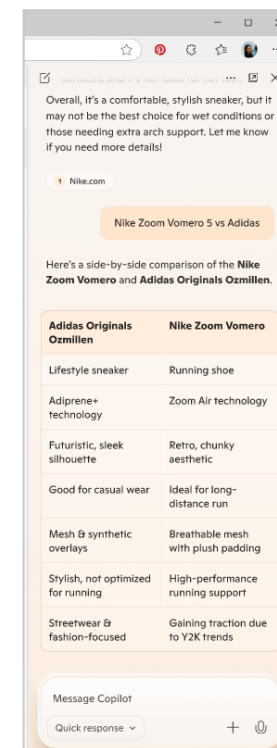
On open:



Resize after typing:



Docked:



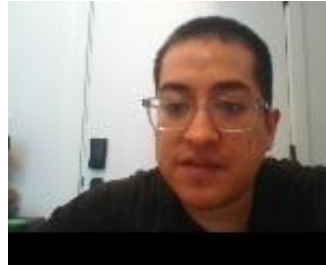
Participants

We recruited 7 US non-Copilot users with experience using Gen AI

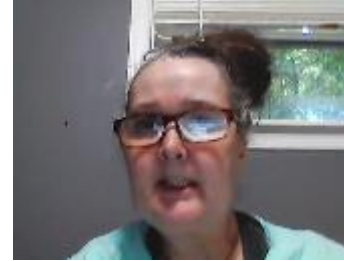
P1



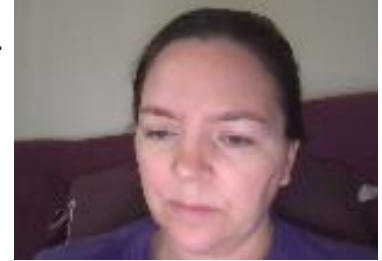
P2



P3



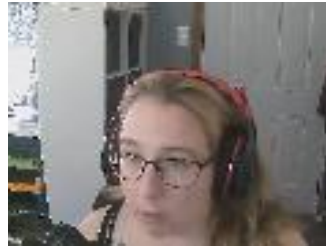
P4



P5



P6



P7



Results

Flex Pane

Results

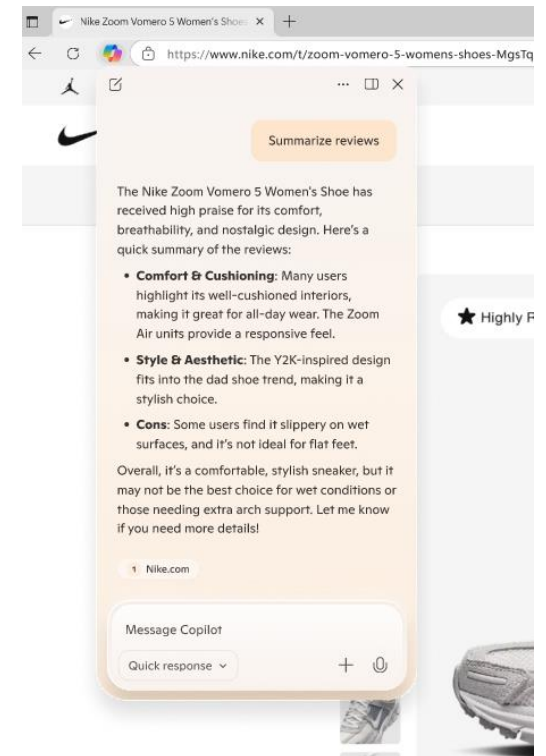
**Does the pane's behavior
match expectations?**

Many participants expected the pane to either shrink or dismiss when they clicked with the screen

Most participants figured the pane would disappear or shrink after they clicked the webpage. As they're focusing on the screen's content, they wouldn't want the larger Copilot pane to distract them or obstruct their view. **A few figured the pane may stay as is, but were uncertain.**

Though some participants expected it to disappear or dismiss, it would be disorienting to reopen Copilot every time they click into the current window. Therefore, shrinking the pane is the solution that preserves screen real estate while meeting users' needs.

“By clicking back to the webpage I’m trying to tell the computer that that’s where my attention is going to go, so I expected it to minimize in some way to give me full access to the screen, visually.” – P7



Recommend | If the pane expanded during conversation, clicking on the page should shrink it down

Whether or not users want the pane to stay open across tabs depends on the relevancy of the follow-up tab

When / why the flex pane should be persistent only on a tab level:

- If it's entirely different content in the new tab, they don't want irrelevant information in the pane
- Even if they're shopping, they may be tabbing quickly away because they lost interest and don't want that information present on the screen
- If they're tabbing to sensitive screens (e.g., bank information) they don't want Copilot assume it has permission to read

When / why the flex pane should be persistent across tabs:

- If it's another shopping tab they may want to compare content across tabs
- It's annoying to have to restart the conversation in a new tab when they're in the middle of a task
- Participants want to control when they open and close the pane

Recommend | Our North Star should be to dynamically respond to the content on the page

Participants generally feel pane should be dismissed when they switch tabs

Why it's a nuisance to have the content showing across tabs:

- It's distracting to see irrelevant content
- Different webpages have different structures so the pane could obstruct their view in unpredictable ways

Keeping content hidden but available is the best of both worlds:

- Because the biggest issue is the potential for the pane to obstruct their view, some participants favored a solution where the pane is dismissed but the conversation is saved

*“I mean I guess... it could be helpful for it to remain open if I’m looking at... a side by side comparison, maybe keeping it up to go to the Adidas website. But even then, **until I get to the exact Adidas page on the site I’m trying to get to, this would still be a nuisance or be in the way depending on where I end up needing to click.**” – P5*

Recommend | Participants expect us to close the pane but keeping the content available across tabs

Results

How do users feel about the Copilot pane size?

Though participants don't object to the size of the pane, some formats may require resizing

During conversation the pane expands, but not too much:

- Participants felt that the pane becomes long enough that they don't need to scroll, but not so long that their view is obstructed
- The pane is small enough to be a quick reference or guide

Future designs should consider output formats where the pane is too thin:

- One participant mentioned they would have trouble reading content any wider than what we have in our prototype

Recommend | The chat pane expands to a good length, but consider in future designs how it would look with wider output.



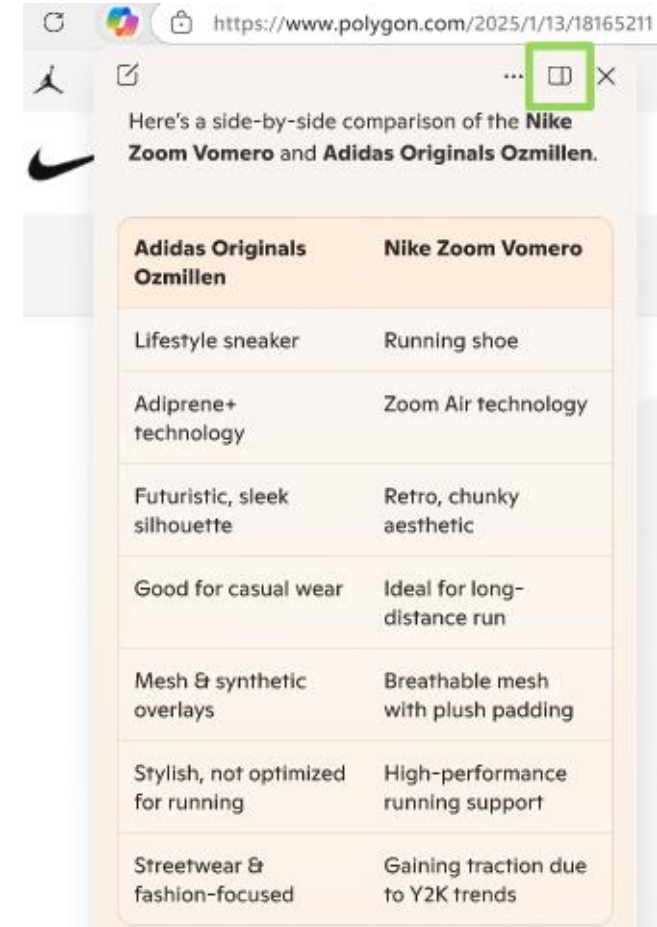
The sidebar icon was difficult for users to understand

Many participants knew the icon indicated some kind of movement **but didn't know it would dock it to the sidebar.**

One participant talked about how an 'open' or 'expand window' icon would make more sense here given its position between the other icons (i.e., close pane and ellipsis), and because the pane expands.

*"I like that there's an option to move it over, I think that's helpful... I'm just not so sure that this icon explains it so much. I wasn't too sure what that is. **I assumed it was how you move it, make it larger, or do something with it, but wasn't entirely sure. I do like the functionality, not so sure about the icon.**" – P2*

Recommend | Replace the icon with something more intuitive (e.g., open window) or add tooltips explaining the pane



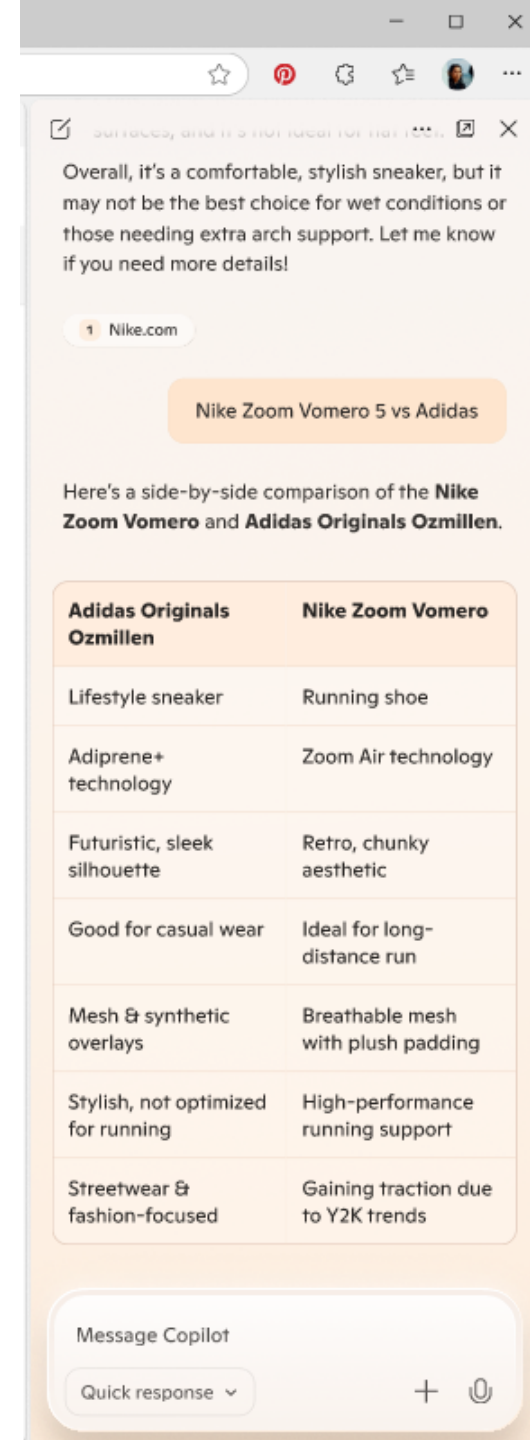
It's not users' first instinct to dock the pane in the sidebar

If we move ahead with this interaction model, we need to make it clearer to participants how docking the pane in the sidebar can help them

Positive reactions to docking in the sidebar:

- Not only is the pane out of the way, there is more vertical space so it minimizes scrolling
- A participant noticed docking it in the sidebar has the same effect as expanding the pane if you can resize the sidebar (aka, you can use it to view wider output)
- One participant felt the chat should start docked since it offers more vertical space and is less obtrusive

Recommend | Explore how to introduce users to the concept of docking the pane



Participants acknowledged that docking in the sidebar solves many problems, but felt dragging and resizing is more intuitive

Users' first instinct may be to move by dragging and resize by grabbing the pane edges

Users may have the mental model that windows can be dragged and resized manually. Many participants talked in-depth about similar experiences where they're able to resize by dragging a corner or pick up and drag a pane across a screen. They recognized these as common actions in their browsers.

There are instances where docking in the sidepane makes less sense

For example, when using Copilot to write an email, it's useful to hold the pane near reference text. Also, the sidebar shrinks the screen, which is undesirable when they need horizontal space.

“So the most intuitive thing for me would be a behavior that I would expect from windows; being able to click and drag and then move it to the side.” – P1

Recommend | Our North Star should be a dragging to resize the pane and moving the pane in addition to docking in the sidebar

Summary of Recommendations

Flex Pane

Recommendations

Pane behavior | If the pane expanded during conversation, clicking on the webpage should shrink it down. The chat pane expands to a good length, but consider in future designs how it would look with wider output.

Longer term tab behavior | Participants expect us to dynamically respond to the content on the page, and to dismiss the pane but keeping the content available across tabs.

Docking in sidebar vs. resizing | Replace the sidebar icon with something more intuitive (e.g., an open window icon) or add tooltips. Explore ways to introduce users to the benefits of docking the chat in the sidebar. Longer term, users should be able to drag / manually resize the pane as well as dock it.